THE SHOW STOPPER

IN 2016, WHEN APARNA PUROHIT informed her father, Visvambhar, that she would be joining Amazon after a 15-year stint with a channel (Sony) and production houses and studios (UTV, Reliance, NFDC), he was disappointed. Once, he had hoped his daughter would crack the IAS. "You told me you are a filmmaker and now you're joining a place that sells watches," he told her. His son had just bought one off Amazon.

Today, Aparna is serving her longest stint, heading content not just for India but for Thailand, the Philippines and Indonesia. "There's never been a dull day since I came in," she says, having started with three people in a co-working space. It has meant expanding the regional shows slate beyond Hindi series, developing documentary series and producing films.

Aparna wants Prime Video to be regarded not just for its shows but also for women's representation and participation. "If a story doesn't pass even the Bechdel test (that a film have two women, who talk to each other, about something other than men), I don't touch it," she says.

Be it the mandate that the writers' room has at least one woman developing a project or that the titles have at least 30 per cent women in HoD positions. This met with "massive pushback" from creators initially. When she suggested women writers be hired for a balanced perspective, she was told there aren't any or enough of them. Aparna and her team scoured IMDB credits and *found* screenplay grads from film schools and passed that database to every creator who walked in.

After all, Aparna has been on the other side. At Chaar Yaar, a boutique production house she had co-founded in 2009, she discovered how difficult it is to get a hearing when you are not with a known company. At Prime Video, every pitch, regardless of who it is from, has to be given "a patient hearing". "Diversity, equity and inclusion" are paramount to her programming slate. It shows, be it *Four More Shots Please!*, *Made in Heaven* or *Rainbow Rishta*. ■

– Suhani Singh

ACCOMPLISHMENT

Making Prime Video India the second largest programming hub after the US with shows like *Mirzapur*, *The Family Man*, *Farzi*



Aparna Purohit, ***44***

Head of Originals, Amazon Prime Video

CORE COMMANDMENT

"There's a massive responsibility in what we greenlight as it shapes how people will live"

↘ **RADIO GA-GA** **While studying at Jamia Millia, Aparna RJ-ed for two shows on 106.4: *Sadabahar Das Gaane* and *Sangeet.com***

↘ **FRIENDLY OVERTURE** **In 2022, started Maitri: Female First Collective, an initiative that celebrates women in the entertainment industry by fostering conversations and collaboration among them**